seats respectively, the alliance of the BJP and the JD(U) had to depend on VIP and HAM(S) to reach the figure of 122. However, within 20 months, the VIP, LJP and BSP have disappeared from the assembly. The JD(U) now has 45 MLAs, including Jama Khan, who shifted from the BSP, and Raj Kumar Singh, who came from the LJP, while the BJP's tally went up to 77 with the VIP MLAs. The two parties of the ruling coalition have 122 MLAs, besides the support of an Independent.

The preference of Leader of the Opposition Tejashwi Yadav for AIMIM MLAs is not without reasons. In 2020, the AIMIM contested in 20 constituencies and won in five. Its success in the minority-dominated seats was seen as an indicator of the RJD's diminished support base among Muslims, and a reason why the Tejashwi-led mahagathbandhan fell short of the majority mark. More crucial than RJD's elevation to the position of single largest party in the assembly again is its ambition to regain the status of being the most preferred political party for Muslim voters in Bihar. After all, Muslims comprise 17 per cent of the population of the state. In fact, the Muslim-Yadav alliance has been the RJD's winning formula for long. The June switchover of AIMIM MLAs may also offset any damage to the RJD by the statement of Heena Shahab, wife of the late RJD MP Mohammed Shahabuddin, that she belonged to no party. Denied a Rajya Sabha nomination, Heena is said to be unhappy with the RJD.

Meanwhile, though there are a few MLAs from small parties in the assembly—four from HAM(S), two each from the CPI(M) and the CPI, and one from AIMIM—nobody expects more switchovers soon as the ruling coalition has a simple majority and the RJD is once again the largest party. However, in the shifting sands of Bihar politics, no one can be too sure. ■

TAMIL NADU/ AIADMK

CHANGING AVATARS

By Amarnath K. Menon

An intense fractious fight has come to a head in the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), bringing an end to the twin leadership in the party, till now shared by Tamil Nadu's last chief minister E. Palaniswami (EPS) and his predecessor O. Panneerselvam (OPS). At the party general council meeting on June 23, an overwhelming majority endorsed the idea of a single leader, and they backed EPS for the job. As expected, the meeting soon turned chaotic, with water bottles being thrown at OPS as he stood firm against the one-leader system. As the majority jeered, OPS was forced to walk out with his supporters.

EPS, who consolidated his position when he was CM for four years, now wants to be the all-powerful general secretary of the AIADMK. Nearly five years after amending the AIADMK constitution to introduce the twin leadership concept—while



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE